

OCR HISTORY A LEVEL

THE DANELAW

DEPTH STUDY



Name: _____

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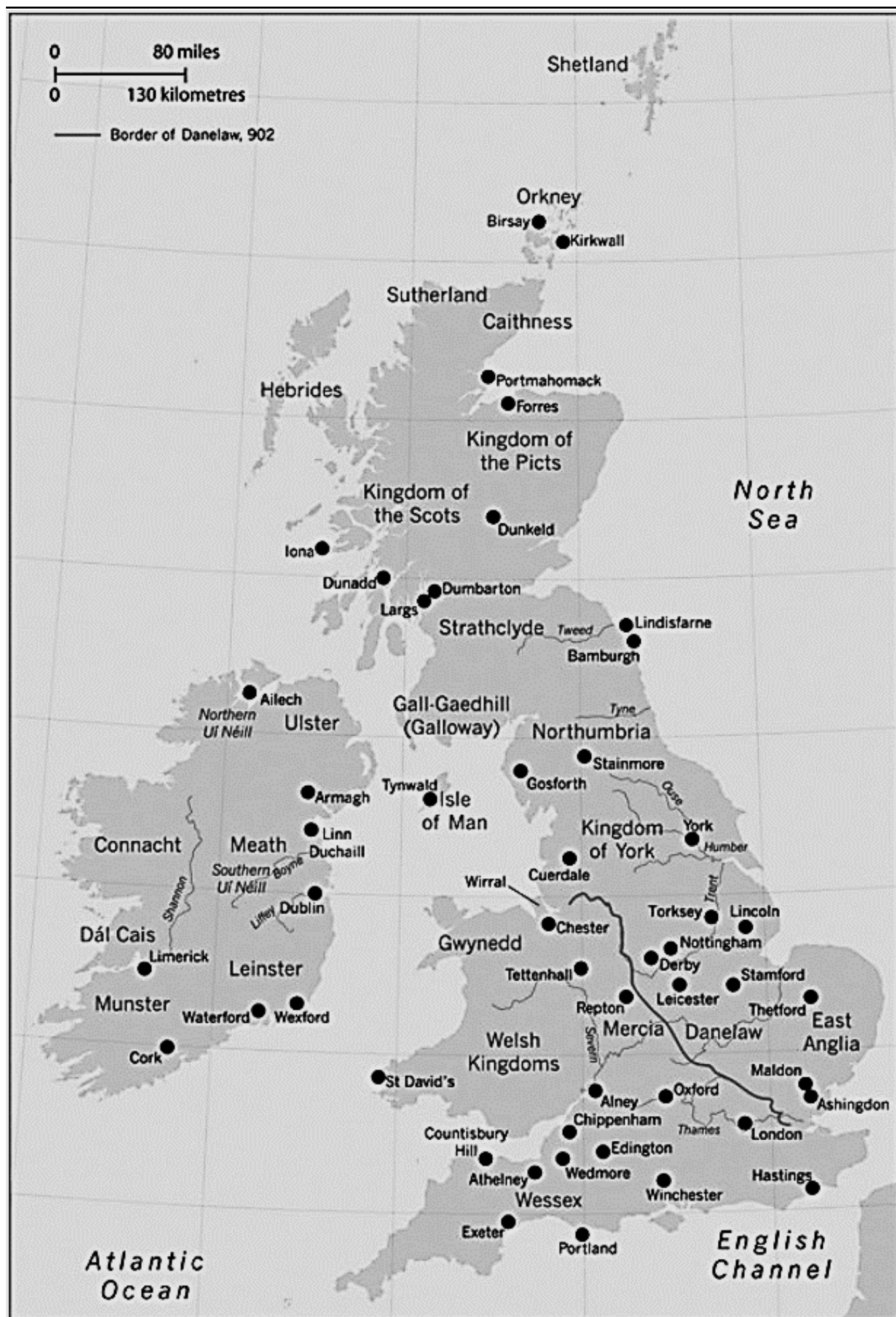
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DEFINITIONS

The Treaty of Alfred and Guthrum

- c.884 The Treaty of Alfred and Guthrum set out the boundaries of Alfred's kingdom: "up on the Thames, and then up on the Lea, and along the Lea unto its source, then straight to Bedford, then up on the Ouse unto Watling Street" ending at the Mersey. Notably, the Danelaw referred to the land north-east of Alfred's border, but it was always atomised and never existed in the sense of a united Viking kingdom.



- The final clause of the treaty agreed that "no slaves or freemen might go over to the [Danish] army without permission." In the past, some Anglo Saxons had joined the Vikings, such as Ealdorman Wulfhere of Wiltshire who was stripped of his lands for "leaving without permission" in 878.
- The Treaty of Alfred and Guthrum created a national identity and began to 'shape an English imagination' (-Sarah Foot). By 886, Alfred signed charters as "rex Angul-Saxonum" (rather than "rex Saxonum") and referred to his people as "Angelcynn" (rather than West Saxons).

Interpretations of Danelaw Settlement

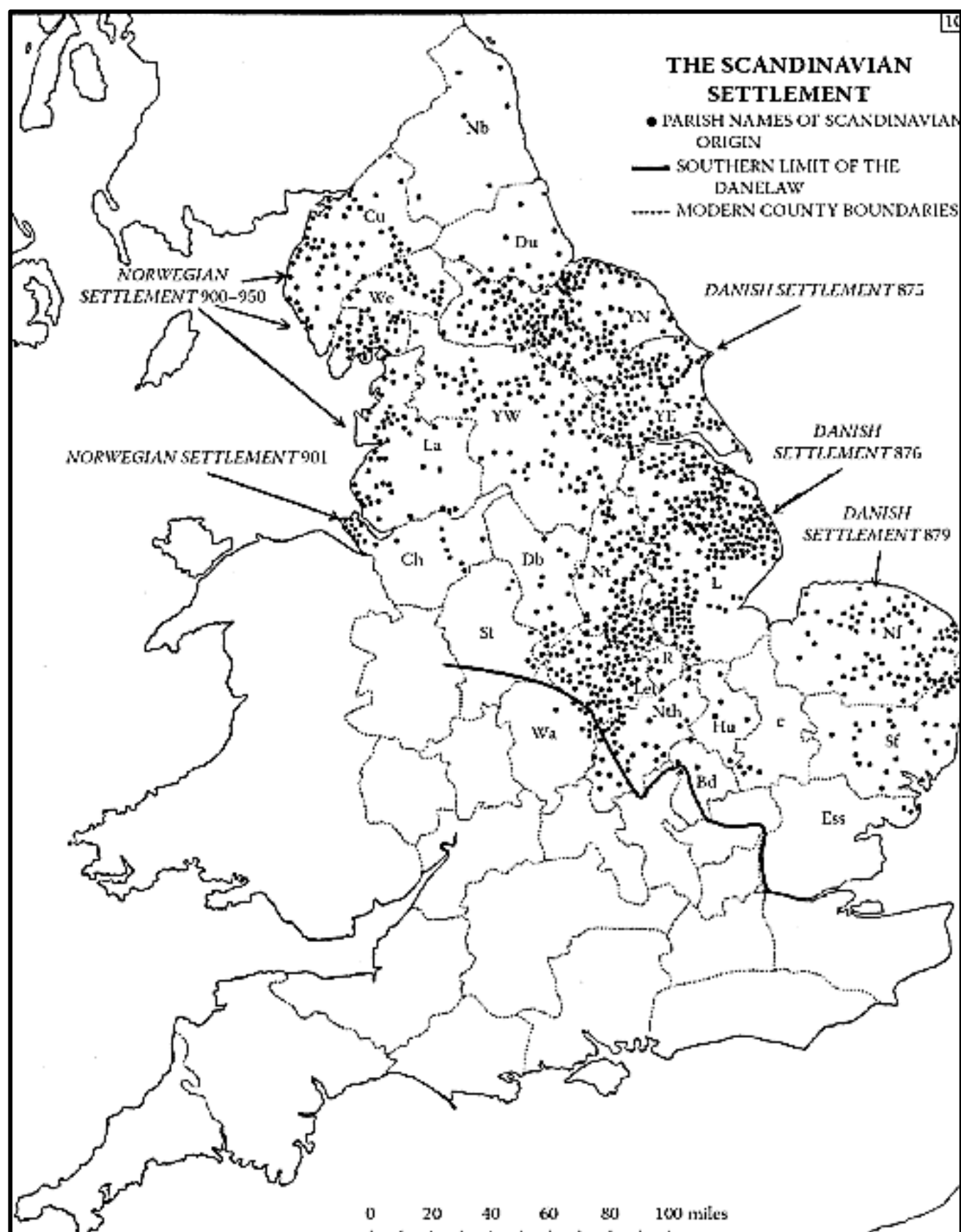
The first Viking encounters in England were hostile but overtime this began to change as members of the armies chose to settle and others began to migrate from Scandinavia. In the end, this left a lasting impact. However, the exact timing and details of how this process unfolded are debated and these four interpretations are all valid in theory:

1. Large Viking armies came to raid England, causing impact. Then several Scandinavians migrated to settle in England, causing further impact.
2. Remnants of large Viking armies settled in England, causing great impact.
3. Remnants of small Viking armies settled in England, causing minor impact. Then several Scandinavians migrated to settle in England, causing great impact.
4. Remnants of small Viking armies settled in England, causing minor impact. Their descendants caused great impact.

Nevertheless, the Danelaw was not a cohesive entity and the reasons for settlement likely varied regionally, meaning that all these interpretations are correct to some extent.

Point of Warning: Anglo-Saxon Bias

- The Viking settlers were illiterate and so our understanding of Viking political impact is very much subject to **pro-Wessex bias** because propagandists would have wanted to make the Vikings seem **as terrible as possible** in order to **make the achievements of Alfred and his descendants seem even greater**. Asser wrote the Life of King Alfred with the rhetoric of hagiography.
- The Anglo Saxon Chronicle describes all Vikings as **'Danes'**, irrespective of where in Scandinavia they came from, and disregards the fact that **some Englishmen fought in Viking armies** - e.g. (878) **Mercian men** formed a large part of the Viking army at **Edington**; (918) **the Battle of Corbridge** saw an army of Englishmen fight under **the Norse King Ragnald**.
- The Anglo-Saxon chronicle underplays the role of **Mercia** in pushing back the Vikings in the **910s** (for knowledge of which we have to rely on **the Mercian Register**).



POLITICAL IMPACT

Toponymy

- According to the Domesday Book, 303 place names in the Five Boroughs have the suffix '-by' (denoting 'farmstead') and 87% of these are Scandinavian compounds.
- When analysing the whole of England, Julian Richards found there to be 850 place names with the suffix 'by', 220 of which were in Yorkshire (i.e. Aislaby, Balby, Brandsby, Dalby, Ferriby, and Selby) and 109 of these are a compound with Scandinavian personal names. In Yorkshire, there are also 155 place names with the suffix '-thorpe' (denoting 'village') (i.e. Bishopthorpe, Danthorpe, Fridaythorpe, and Towthorpe).
- Across the Five Boroughs, there are 50 'Grimston hybrids' combining Scandinavian names with Anglo-Saxon land units (e.g. Burnestone, Scampston, Wigginton, Grimston, and Olaveshide). These hybrid place names generally apply to villages that were under Scandinavian ownership but not under direct control.
- Viking dialect changed the pronunciation of Anglo-Saxon place names such as Shipton which became Skipton, and Cheswick which became Keswick.

Toponymy suggests that the Vikings exercised dominance in the regions they settled but notably, it is not guaranteed for an area with a Scandinavian place-name to have been ruled over or even populated by Vikings. For example, the Ulfr who held the manor at Cottam in 1086 may have been a descendant of Halfdan's Heathen Army, partly Scandinavian, or even purely Anglo-Saxon.

The legal system

- The Wantage code of Aethelred the Unready accounts for the Five Boroughs having a system of courts: at the top, there was The Court of the Five Boroughs which was presided over by an ealdorman; second, the courts of each Borough; third, the Wapentake courts which were presided over by 12 Thanes who had each sworn an oath on holy relics that they would neither accuse the innocent nor shield the guilty. This was the first assertion in England of the principle that, where opinions differ, the opinion of the majority must prevail.
- England adopted the Scandinavian 12-man jury system, and several legal terms e.g. Lagemanni (lawmen), Labslit (breach of law), Labcop (purchase of law), and Festerman (surety). In 1106, York is noted to have had a jury of 12 Lagemanni. Juries of Lagemanni are also noted in Cambridge, Chester, Lincoln, and Stamford.

Crown finances

- The proportion of moneyers during the 9th-10th centuries with Scandinavian names increased from 0 under Alfred (886-899), to 3% under Edward the Elder (899-924), to 5% under Aethelstan (924-927), and 15% under Eadred (946-955). In York, this was the case for 75% of the moneyers of Aethelred the Unready (978-1013) but was still only 7% in London.
- Before the Vikings, wics were built for kings to levy tolls and control foreign exchanges. However, under the system of burhs (built as a system of national defence against Viking raids), the Crown had to enforce their administration on the trade that took place on these sites:
 - Edward the Elder's First Law Code decreed that "no one shall buy or sell except in a market town with the witness of the port-reeve and of other men of credit."
 - Aethelstan's Second Law Code decreed that "no one shall buy goods worth more than 20 pence, outside a town; but he shall buy within the town, in the presence of the port-reeve or some other trustworthy man."

Indirect impact

- The Vikings' destruction of three Anglo-Saxon kingdoms disrupted the pre-existing political structures in England which aided King Alfred's political agenda because it allowed Wessex to 'shape an English imagination' (- Sarah Foot) and establish a national identity. In 866, Ealdorman Aethelred married Alfred's daughter to unite the surviving English kingdoms against the Vikings but in the long term, after the death of Aethelred in 911 and Aethelflaed in 918, this meant Mercia was 'absorbed by the Alfredian blob'. (-G.K.Chesterton)
- Throughout the 9th and 10th centuries, an estimated 20,000-35,000 Vikings settled and assimilated across northern and eastern England, bringing aspects of their own culture. 'Regionally and generally the influx of the Scandinavians made a vital contribution to the inner nature of the English communities of the Middle Ages.' (H.R.Loyn).
- The precautions taken to fortify England against Viking attacks strengthened England thereafter, for example: the establishment of fyrds, burhs, Alfred's navy, and the strengthening of towns such as Nottingham (having been occupied by Vikings in 868, Edward the Elder recaptured the city in 918 and built a second burh on its south bank and connected it to the existing burh with a bridge).

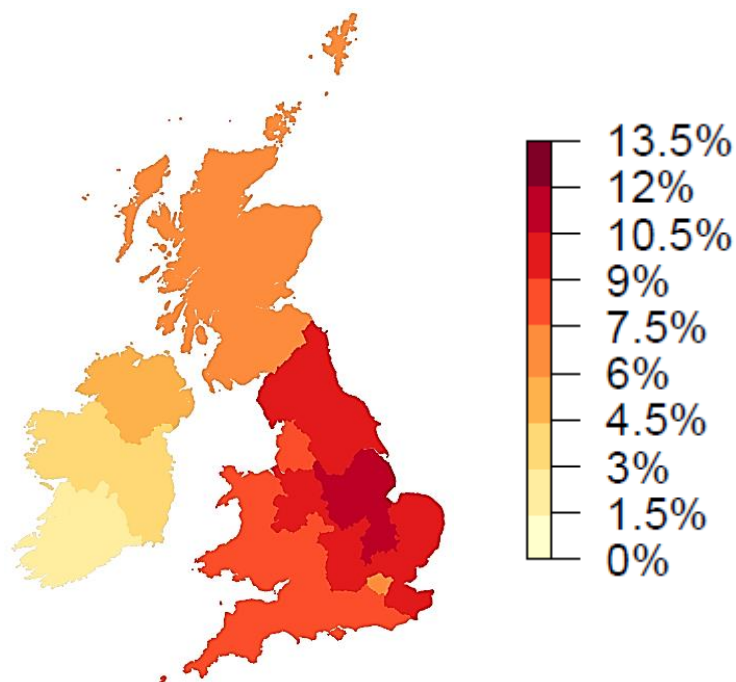
Areas of little impact

- Unique Viking weighing standards can only be seen in major towns of the Danelaw.
- The church of St Paul-in-the-Bail in Lincoln was continuously upkeep despite it being at the heart of the Viking-occupied Roman fortress (Lincoln castle).
- In the 9th century, the Vikings established a mint at Thetford but the town never became an international trading port. By 1066 the settlement south of the river had been deserted in favour of a smaller settlement to the north.
- The Great Heathen Army established a temporary settlement at St Peter's church in Northampton that had once acted as a minster and palace, but, after their departure, the site was abandoned until the 11th century.
- In many cases such as York, the Vikings contributed to the growth of the urban community but, crucially, did not create it.
- In the early 8th century, royal and ecclesiastical lands were already being broken up and sold, the Vikings merely accelerated this process.
- Peter Sawyer argued that the lack of material culture in the Danelaw reflects that the Viking settlers assimilated quickly into the Anglo-Saxon population and 'became effectively indistinguishable.' It is also perhaps indicative that in the early stages there weren't many Vikings who settled.
- The Vikings founded no urban centres on the Isle of Man.
- 896 - The Anglo-Saxon Chronicle thought that the Great Heathen Army had had a short-term impact but "had not on the whole afflicted the English people very greatly."

SOCIAL IMPACT

Genetics

- DNA analysis estimates that 20,000-35,000 Scandinavians migrated to England and mixed with the Anglo-Saxon population. Notably, this native Anglo-Saxon population was a composite of migrant peoples and so attempting to quantify the number of Scandinavian settlers through means of genealogy is **inexact**, and the Oxford University's People of the British Isles Project concluded that there was **'no clear genetic evidence of the Danish Viking occupation.'**
- In **902**, the Irish expelled Norwegian Vikings from Dublin, driving them to northwest England where they then invaded **Mercia** but were repelled by **Aethelred**. Their leader, **Ingamund**, appealed to **Aethelflaed** for lands and she allowed him to settle on **the Wirral peninsula** near Chester. Today, **50%** of Wirral's population shares distinctive genetic markers with the people of **Norway**.
- In 993, the Mercian Register notes that the leaders of Lindsey, who chose to not fight the Vikings, had **Danish ancestry**; 20 years later the people of Lindsey supported **Cnut of Denmark** in his claim to be king. This suggests that the people of Lindsey had a distinct identity and perhaps ethnicity.
- The Vikings caused communities to reshuffle as the rural dispossessed sought new areas for settlement. For example, an anonymous History of St Cuthbert records the flight of an abbot and of a nobleman called **Alfred son of Brihtwulf** who crossed **the Pennines** to escape the Vikings.



A map of the average AncestryDNA Scandinavian ethnicity.

CULTURAL IMPACT

Language

- Old English and Old Norse were mutually intelligible so a sort of lingua franca arose in the Danelaw. The words for 'birth', 'ill', 'rugged', 'tight', 'happy', 'egg', and 'dirt' are of Norse origin and were borrowed from this 'Danish tongue'. As opposed to 11th century French loan words that are typically associated with administrative topics, these Norse loan words suggest that the Scandinavians did not strictly oppress the Anglo-Saxon inhabitants because they are typically associated with farming and daily life.
- Norse names for classes of men were applied, for example:
 - The term Dreng (ON Drangr) referred to a well-off peasant in South Lancashire
 - the term Sokeman (ON Sokn) referred to a superior landowning peasant in Hertfordshire
 - The term Hold (ON Holdr) referred to a free landowner in Northumbria, who had a wergold of 4000 thrymsas - equal to that of a king's high-reeve.
- Norse measurements of land were applied, for example:
 - Regions of land big enough to have a court had been measured in 'Hundreds' but the Vikings renamed them 'Wapentakes' (because voting in an assembly was done by a show of weapons).
 - Farmland had been measured in 'Hides' (120 acres of land believed to be adequate to support one family) but the Vikings measured in 'Carucates' (the land tillable by eight oxen in a ploughing season) and 'Oxgangs' (the land tillable by one ox in a ploughing season).
 - The Vikings divided Yorkshire into its 3 Ridings with the unit 'Thrithjungl', a term also applied in Gotland.

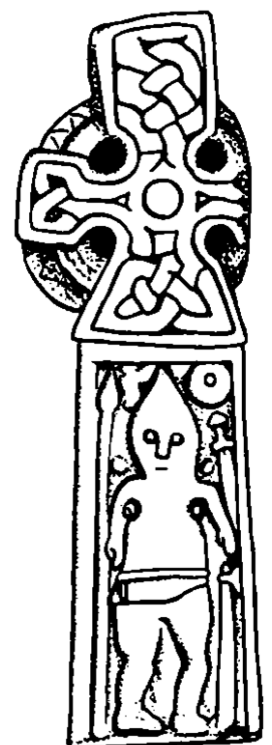
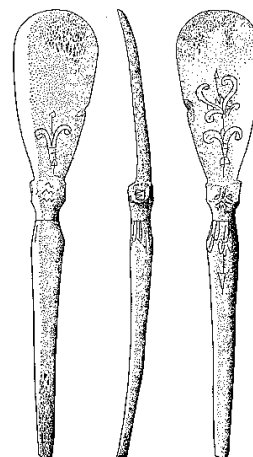
Fashion

- Jane Kershaw examined Anglo-Scandinavian brooches and observed **Norfolk** and **Lincolnshire** to be the most saturated with examples, concluding that **'brooches in Scandinavian styles were commonplace.'**
- The backwards-biting Jellinge-style animal motif found on Scandinavian pendants was applied to the Anglo-Saxon disc brooches. For example, a **copper-alloy disc brooch** found at Cottam - probably bought from a metalworker in **York** - was decorated with **a backwards-biting dragon** in Jellinge-style.

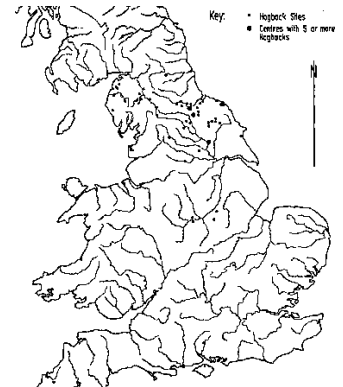


Art

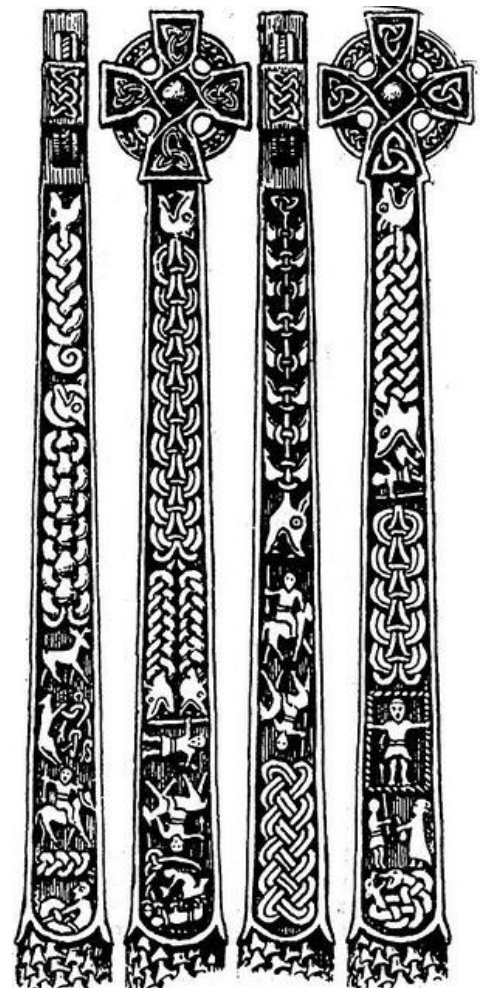
- One of the seven Middleton crosses, found in North Yorkshire, depicts on one side a **deceased Viking warrior buried in a conical helmet and surrounded by weapons**, and on the other side, a **serpent decorated in Jellinge-style**.
- The Anglo-Saxon Winchester style, which favoured the Carolingian motif of **a vertical acanthus stem**, merged with the Norse Ringerike-style of art to create the hybrid **'Ringerike-Winchester style'**. For example, **6 bone spatulate spoons** from Winchester were engraved with acanthus stem patterns.



- Hogback tombstones, found only in northwest England and Ireland, are shaped in Irish design and decorated with intertwined monsters in Jellinge-style. They were popular with the Anglo-Scandinavian aristocracy.



- The Gosforth Cross, found in Cumbria, is a 4.5m-high free-standing stone cross decorated in Borre and Jellinge-style depicting the Day of Judgement with borrowed images of Ragnarok; Mary Magdalen is depicted with a trailing dress like a Valkyrie.



- A runestone in the churchyard of St Paul's Cathedral depicts a backwards-biting dragon-like creature.

Religion

- The scholar Alcuin explained that the Lindisfarne raid was **God punishing Christians**, which led many Anglo-Saxons and Alfred himself to believe that the Viking raids were **manifestations of divine justice**.
- Due to Viking raids targeting **monastic sites**, episcopal lists for churches in the Danelaw were **interrupted for several decades**, for example: the episcopal succession of **Lindsey's** bishopric was interrupted from **875-953**, and those in **Leicester** and **Hexham** were destroyed completely.
- In **c.891**, **Pope Formosus** issued a papal letter to the bishops of England, complaining that **"the abominable rites of the pagans have sprouted again in your parts."**
- Alfred's biographer, **Asser**, writing in **893**, consistently refers to the Vikings as **'Pagani'** (pagans).
- Place names such as **Toreswe** (shrine of Thor) in north Lincolnshire show that the Norse deities were **actively worshipped** in the Viking Age.
- An Anglo-Saxon female skeleton was found buried beside **a horse** in a Christian graveyard in Norfolk - perhaps suggesting an Anglo-Scandinavian presence as seen in Scandinavian lore (e.g. **the Saga of Grettir**) and as a funerary motif (e.g. **Gausel cemetery in Norway**), but nonetheless, this is fairly speculative.
- Thor's hammer pendants have been found across England, for example in **Repton** and **Torksey**.
- In 1014, Archbishop Wulfstan II of York lamented that: **"it happens that a slave escapes from his lord and leaves Christendom to become a Viking"; "God's dues have for too long dwindled away in every region within this nation"; "the laws of the people have deteriorated"; "sanctuaries are commonly violated"**.
- Over time, Norse paganism died out as the new generations practised Christianity in earnest. For example, **Oda**, the son of a Danish invader, became **Archbishop of Canterbury** in 941, issued **monastic reforms**, and was recognised as **a saint** after his death in 958. In 1055, **the Church of St Olave** (named after the Norwegian King Olaf Haraldsson) was established in **York**.

ECONOMIC IMPACT

Numismatics

The Vikings valued coins for their weight in **bullion** but Viking leaders chose to embrace the **Roman** tradition. This flexibility indicates their willingness to compromise for the sake of being considered **a legitimate Christian king**.

- In the 880s, Guthrum minted coins in the traditional Roman fashion: bearing his Christian name **"EDELSTAN REX"** and the name of the moneyer. Notably, his imitations consistently misspelt the mint name Ohснаforda as **Orснаforda** (with an R rather than an H).



(1) The penny of King Alfred of Wessex; (2) The penny of King Guthrum of East Anglia.

- In the **890s**, the Vikings minted coins that honoured **"SC EADMUND REX A"** (Saint Edmund, King of the Angles) despite being responsible for **his death in 869**.
- Throughout the Viking Age in York, over **30 designs** were minted displaying the symbol of Thor's hammer, and in c.915, Mjolnir was illustrated alongside **the sword of Saint Peter**. Olaf Guthfrithsson minted coins displaying **Odin's raven**.



Coins from York showing the sword of Saint Peter, Thor's hammer, and a raven.

Urbanisation

- Primarily, the Danelaw was comprised of the Kingdom of York, the Kingdom of East Anglia, and the Five Boroughs (Derby, Leicester, Lincoln, Nottingham, and Stamford). Before the Viking Age, none of the Five Boroughs were urban or fortified sites but, under the Vikings, they became the fastest-growing towns of the 9th century.
- Out of the Five Boroughs, the Viking presence in Lincoln is known best. The area had once been occupied by the Romans, but the Roman fortress and the soon-to-be Flaxengate had not been inhabited since. In c.874, the Vikings reorganised Lincoln's streets into zones of manufacturing, and labelled them with the Old Norse suffix '-gate' (denoting a street), for example:
 - Flaxengate - Flax Street
 - Saltergate - Salt Street
 - Michaelgate - Michael Street
 - Hungate - Hound Street
- Excavations have shown that the Vikings brought new trade connections to Lincoln, for example:
 - Pottery vessels from the Low Countries
 - Basalt querns from the Rhineland
 - Whetstones from Norway
 - Amber from the Baltic
- Two grave covers in the cemetery of St Mark are decorated in Borre-style, and this has been used to suggest the presence of a Scandinavian elite in Lincoln (much like hogback tombstones in northeast England).
- Although the Lincoln-Vikings surrendered to Edward the Elder in 918, their presence had laid the foundations for Lincoln's prosperity during the Middle Ages. The establishment of the Lincoln mint in the mid-10th century coincides with Flaxengate's economic boom as an industrial centre for glass and copper-alloy jewellery, and notably, Lincoln's mint had the second most amount of moneyers (second only to London) many of whom had Scandinavian names, such as: Grind, Grim, and Hafgrim. By 1066, Lincoln had a population of 6,000.

Torksey

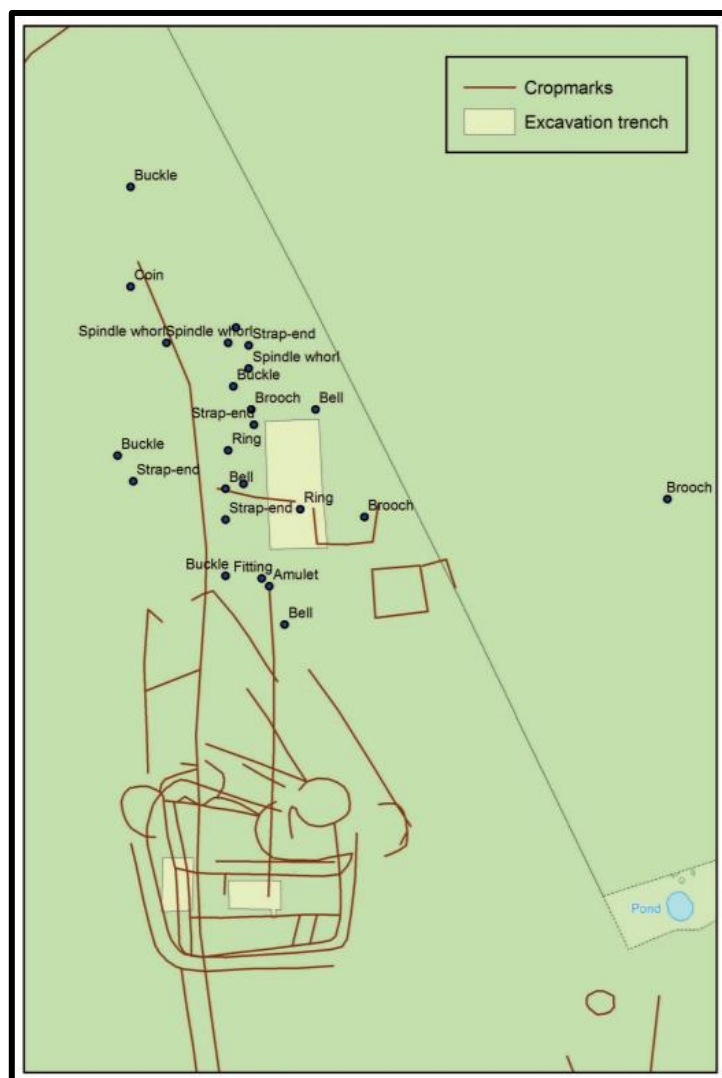
- The excavations at Torksey demonstrate how the Vikings founded new industries and urbanised Anglo-Saxon settlements. Most notably, excavations have shown that Torksey developed a major pottery industry. The presence of spindle whorls, needles, punches and awls suggest that Torksey also had a textile industry. Notably, with 289 lead gaming pieces being found and the only military-related artefacts being two iron spearheads, an iron sword hilt and an arrowhead, Torksey demonstrates the humanity of the Great Heathen Army.
 - Typical Anglo-Saxon pottery was hand-built from individual coils of clay, then individually fired on a bonfire. Torksey ware was thrown on a potter's kick wheel, wrapped in fabric, and fired in a kiln at 800-850°C producing pottery with a unique black pimply design; with 15 kilns having been found at the site, pottery could be produced at a quicker rate and en masse.
- 
- 872-873 - the Vikings overwinter at Torksey, Lincolnshire.
 - Late-9th century - Torksey ware appears throughout northern and eastern England.
 - By the 12th century - Torksey was one of the most important pottery industries in England, the town had three parish churches, two monasteries, and a court. In 1015, the Anglo-Saxon Chronicle references the Seven Boroughs and it is thought that Torksey and York were the new additions.

Wharram

- An Anglo-Saxon settlement, containing a timber hall and an ironsmith's workshop, that was surrendered to Viking raiders in the 9th century. The figurehead converted the timber hall into a medieval manor house, built a small timber church, and was buried on church grounds in a bowed grave typical of Scandinavian royalty.
- At Wharram, an Anglo-Saxon copper-alloy buckle was discovered decorated with Borre-style interlace.
- Within decades, the farmstead became a Christian village that would survive and flourish throughout the 12th-14th centuries.

Cottam

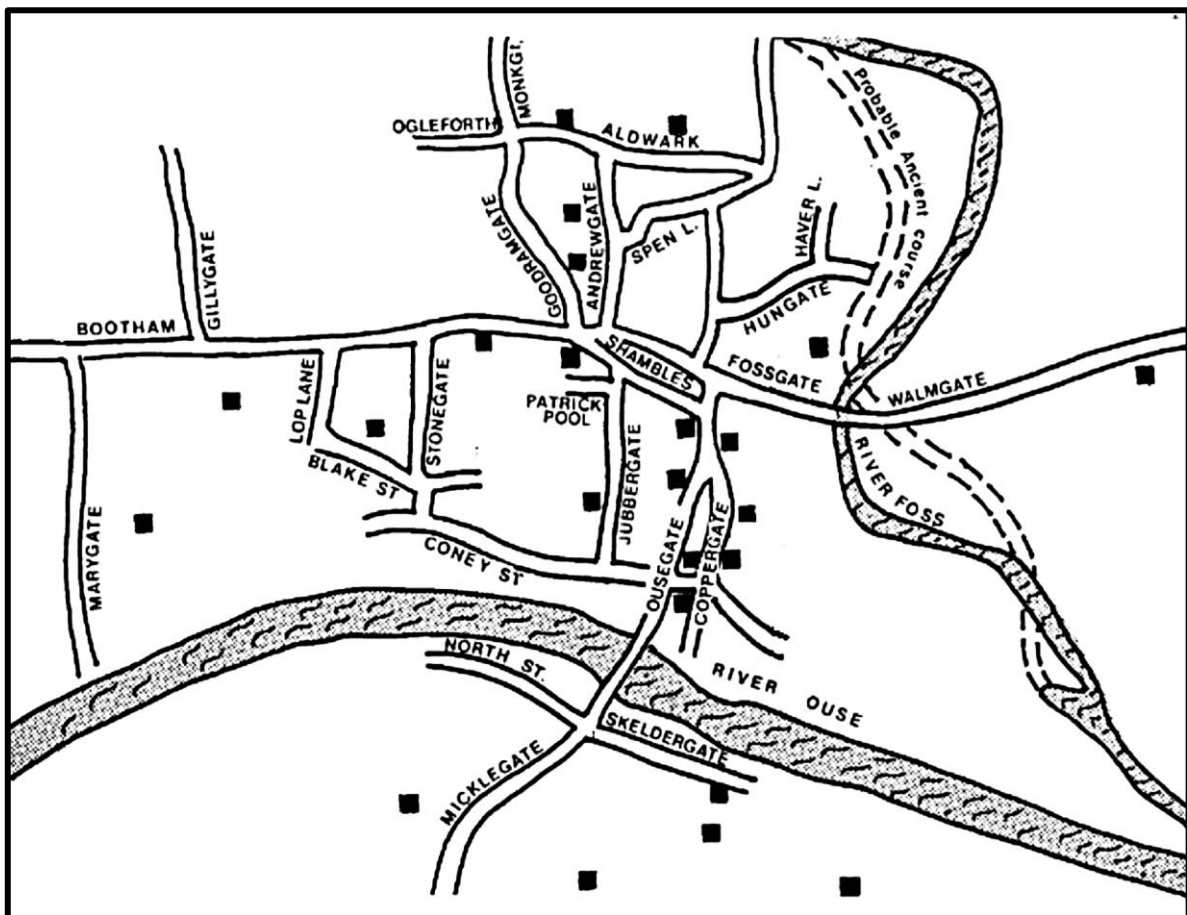
- **8th century** - a small Anglo-Saxon settlement, containing a two timber hall vill and several workshops, is established.
- **870s** - an offshoot from the Great Heathen Army pass through Cottam causing the Anglo-Saxon population to abandon the site. The Vikings leave behind: two spearheads, the hilt of a sword, a globule of molten silver, a silver dirham, a pecked sceat of King Eadberht of Northumbria (r.738-758), and 17 lead weights.
- **10th century** - Vikings return to Cottam with domestic intentions and establish a farmstead. The Anglo-Scandinavian population leave behind: wool combs, 26 buckles, 8 lead spindle whorls, 2 Norse bells, and an Anglo-Saxon copper-alloy disc brooch depicting a Jellinge-style backwards biting dragon. The figurehead built a burh-geat (gatehouse), which Archbishop Wulfstan II of York describes as one of the five criteria to become a Thane. Notably, the farmstead's general lack of defence suggests that the settlers were peaceful and did not fear attacks. After two generations, Cottam is abandoned.



YORK

The Northumbrian Renaissance

- The Vikings greatly contributed to the growth of York's urban community but, crucially, did not **create the city**, having been founded by **the Romans** in 71 (**Eboracum**) and ruled by **Anglo-Saxons** since 400 (**Eoforwic**) - York had already been the major capital of northern England.
- It was an important royal centre for **the Northumbrian kings**; it was a centre of learning, with **a library** and **Minster school** where the renowned scholar **Alcuin** was educated and later worked; and it was the second most important ecclesiastical centre in England (next only to **Canterbury**) on account of its **archbishopric** since 735, and its history of **Saint Paulinus** setting up a wooden church that **Saint Edwin** was then baptised in in 627.



Plan of York showing Coppergate and other Viking street names.

Kings of York

- **867** - The Great Heathen Army take advantage of civil disputes between Aella and Osberht, and conquer Northumbria; they rename York to Jorvik and establish the puppet king Ecgberht whilst continuing to raid England.
- **876-883**: In 876, Halfdan distributed land in Northumbria amongst his men, who "ploughed the land and provided for themselves," but also destroyed several monasteries. In 883, Halfdan died and was succeeded by Guthfrith.
- **883-895**: Guthfrith appears to have converted to Christianity because when he died in 895 he was buried in York Minster.
- **895-900**: Sigfrid mints coins as "Rex Siefredus" which are later found in the Cuerdale Hoard. In 900, Sigfrid died and was succeeded by Cnut.
- **900-905**: Cnut mints coins as "Rex Cnut" with "Rex Alfred" on the reverse, which are later found in the Cuerdale Hoard. In 905, Cnut died and Northumbria becomes unstable.
- **910** - Edward the Elder and Aetheflaed had allied to take advantage of Northumbria, and the Battle of Tettenhall saw the Northumbrian Danes retaliate but be defeated; the Viking kings Haldfan, Ivar and Eowils are killed.
- **919-921**: using Dublin as a base to campaign in northern England, Ragnald captures York. In 921, Ragnald died and his brother Sihtric Caech ('Squinty') chose to give his kingship of Dublin to his other brother Guthfrith so that he could take the kingship of York.
- **921-927**: In 927, Sihtric Caech ('Squinty') is defeated by King Aethelstan who is then able to extend his rule into Northumbria; it is at this point that Aethelstan appropriately calls himself the King of all England.
- **939** - King Aethelstan dies having united all of England under a single ruler; he is succeeded by his half-brother, Edmund.
- **940** - the absence of Aethelstan allows Olaf Guthfrithsson to re-establish Viking rule over the Danelaw.
- **941** - Olaf Guthfrithsson dies on campaign and is succeeded by his cousin Olaf Sihtricsson.
- **944** - King Edmund temporarily recaptures York from Olaf Sihtricsson.
- **946** - King Edmund dies and is succeeded by his brother Eadred.
- **948** - Erik Bloodaxe temporarily recaptures York.
- **954** - The last remaining Viking King in England, Eric Bloodaxe, is defeated and York is incorporated back into Anglo-Saxon territory under King Eadred; Eric flees York across the Pennine hills but is killed.

Jorvik

- Before the Vikings, York's trade connections had only included the rest of England, northern France, and the Low Countries. The Vikings extended York's trade network:
 - A set of walrus ivory dice from the Arctic.
 - A cowrie shell from the Persian Gulf.
 - A high-status silk cap from Byzantium.
 - Amber necklaces from the Baltic.
 - Basalt querns from Scandinavia and Germany.
 - Gold and silver from Ireland.
 - Silver dirhams from Samarkand.
 - Tin from Cornwall.
- The Vikings redesigned York's city plan along wider plots and built equal-sized two-storey structures with gardens; craftsmen would store raw materials in the cellar, and live and work on the ground floor. Streets were reorganised into zones of manufacturing and labelled with the Old Norse suffix '-gate' (denoting a street), for example:
 - Coppergate, Cup-maker Street
 - Skeldergate, Shield-maker Street
 - Swinegate, Pig Street
 - Micklegate, the Great Street
 - Goodramgate, Guthrum Street
- By the 10th century, the silver content of York's coinage had increased and, based on the large amount of preserved coinage, scales and weights, this indicates a flourishing market. The Life of St Oswald attests that York was "enriched with the treasures of merchants, who come from all parts, but above all from the Danish people."
- Analysis of human excrement and the increasing density of York's building plots suggest that York's population was rapidly increasing; it is estimated to be c.10,000 by 1000, and c.15,000 by 1066, making it the second-largest city in England (next only to London).
- Notably, after 954, developments in York occur but were not the direct result of Viking policies but still could have been due to the legacy of the Viking Kings (i.e. Anglo-Saxon Kings mimicking Viking Kings) or due to the Scandinavian settlers in York.

Coppergate

Coppergate, meaning Cup-maker Street or Wood-turner Street, had 4 tenements measuring 35x65m with two-storey timber buildings each 7x4.5m. The excavations carried out in the 1970s found 40,000 objects, indicating the sorts of industry present at Coppergate:

- **Woodworking** - wood shavings, tools, and hundreds of wooden cores have been found, indicating that cups and bowls were mass-produced.
- **Metalworking** - metal-separating trays, crucibles and moulds have been found, indicating that a blacksmith was stationed at Coppergate.
- **Leatherworking** - leather shoes, belts, pouches, and elaborately decorated scabbards were made at Coppergate.
- **Bone carving** - reindeer antler was imported from the Arctic and then developed at Coppergate into pins, amulets, and combs.

The importance of York

1. Even before the Vikings, York had been the major capital of the north and was recognised as an important royal, ecclesiastical, and educational centre.
2. Northumbria was the first Anglo-Saxon kingdom captured by the Great Heathen Army (867), and York was the first permanent Viking settlement in England and was dubbed a kingdom. Thereafter, the Great Heathen Army returned to overwinter (868-869) and withdrew to York when threatened (870 by King Aethelred and Alfred).
3. Viking leaders strove to be King of York; in 921, Sihtric Caech ('Squinty') gave up his Kingship of Dublin to become the King of York, likewise in 927, his elder brother Guthfrith tried to do the same but was expelled by Aethelstan.
4. It was only after capturing York in 927 that Aethelstan saw it appropriate to call himself King of all England.
5. Under the Vikings, York became an extremely important trade centre, with unique trade connections and reorganised industries.
6. York was 87 acres large, making it the largest Viking settlement. By 1066 it had 15,000 inhabitants, making it the second-largest city in England by population.
7. York was the settlement which the Vikings were associated with and had control over for the longest period (867-954).

HOARDS

The Cuerdale Hoard

The largest Viking hoard from Anglo-Saxon England, discovered in 1840, containing 8600 objects, and weighing 40kg. There were 7500 silver coins - 40% were issued at York by Sigfrid and Cnut, but others show extensive trade links (Byzantine, Carolingian, Islamic, North Italian, Papal, Scandinavian). There were also scraps of hacksilver and ring-money.



The Harrogate Hoard

The second-largest Viking hoard from Anglo-Saxon England discovered in 2007 and containing 682 objects. There were 617 silver coins - showing trade links (Birka, Carolingian, Irish, Islamic, North African, Russian). There were also scraps of hacksilver, silver arm-rings and one golden arm-ring.



The Bedale Hoard

A Viking hoard from Anglo-Saxon England discovered in 2012 and containing 48 objects. The Bedale Hoard's origin in the 9th century and lack of coinage (in comparison to the 10th century Cuerdale and Harrogate hoards) shows that Viking settlers initially valued bullion but adopted local customs.



OVERVIEW

Origins: After the Battle of Edington in 878, treaties were necessary as neither the Anglo-Saxons nor Vikings were in a far superior position. Alfred could not expel the Vikings completely, and most likely recognised that their presence had aided his political agenda. Guthrum was most likely content with his conquests and the kingship of East Anglia.

Organisation: The Danelaw referred to the land north-east of Alfred's border, but it was always atomised and never existed in the sense of a united Viking kingdom. The fact that the Danelaw was not a cohesive entity meant that its organisation and reasons for settlement likely varied regionally.

Growth: From the creation of the Danelaw in c.884 there was a period of consolidation until the 910s when Edward the Elder and Aethelflaed began the process of reclaiming the Danelaw.

Anglo-Saxon Response: Having been overpowered by Guthrum in January 878, Alfred the Great sought to salvage the national identity of England, and initiated an effective response (e.g. burhs, fyrds, and navy) to prevent further Viking triumphs from happening. His descendants (Edward the Elder, Lady Aethelflaed, and Athelstan) had a more effective response that established English superiority over the Vikings by reclaiming the Five Boroughs, and promoting Alfred's 'English imagination'.

York: The Vikings redesigned York's city plan to make manufacturing goods more efficient, and introduced lucrative industries and new trade connections. Despite their great contribution, the Vikings did not transform the importance of York as it had already been recognised as the major capital of the north due to its association with the Northumbrian royalty, the Church, and education.

Political impact: the Vikings destroyed 3 of the Anglo-Saxon kingdoms, and toponymy in the Danelaw suggests that the Vikings maintained their political dominance in these regions. Indirectly, the Vikings were responsible for the Anglo-Saxons developing stronger fortifications, and assisting Alfred's political agenda regarding an 'English imagination'.

Social impact: in the short-term, the Viking identity was distinct from the native Anglo-Saxons' but, in the long-term, the process of assimilation and genetic implications of mass migration (25,000-30,000 Scandinavians) gave rise to an Anglo-Scandinavian society in the Danelaw. Whilst this is evident in most regions, the atomised nature of the Danelaw meant that some areas retained their Scandinavian links more than others.

Cultural impact: Viking art styles and fashion trends gradually influenced Anglo-Saxon culture, creating hybrid/syncretic art. Likewise, various Old Norse words were adopted into English, regarding daily life, land measurements, and the legal and class systems.

Religious impact: in the short term, the Vikings disregarded Christianity and continued to practice paganism, however, Christianity quickly prevailed due to the process of assimilation and the conversion of leaders (whether genuine or not).

Economic impact: in the short term, Viking raiding shocked England and made it poorer but, in the long term, Viking settlement brought new trade connections and industries that made England richer.

YEAR	EVENT
Before 789	Norse kingdoms develop trade links that extend westward into the British Isles and Ireland.
789	3 Norwegian ships land at Portland and, after a disagreement, kill Beaduheard the reeve of Dorchester; this is the first recorded Viking attack.
792	King Offa of Mercia commissions coastal defences to protect Kent from "pagan seamen" (- a Kentish charter).
793 June 8th	The Vikings raid the Holy Island of Lindisfarne and pillage St Cuthbert's monastery where they killed and enslaved many of its monks; this is the first recorded Viking raid.
794	The Vikings burn the Monkwearmouth-Jarrow Abbey, a highly prestigious monastery that had once housed the Venerable Bede, however, local forces fight back and kill the Viking leader as well as 2/5 of the raiding party while they failed to escape due to stormy weather; notably, no raids against England are recorded for 40 years.
795, 802, 806, 807	The Vikings raid the island monastery of Iona in Scotland.
795	The Vikings raid the island monastery of Lambay in Ireland; The Annals of Ulster note how heathens caused the "devastation of all the islands of Britain".
804	The monks of Lyminge in Kent take refuge in Canterbury, suggesting that the Viking threat had not completely vanished in England.
809	The Vikings capture the papal legate Ealdwulf as he returns from Northumbria; his ransom is paid by King Coenwulf of Mercia.
825	The Battle of Ellandun sees King Egbert of Wessex defeat King Beorhtwulf of Mercia.
835	The Vikings raid the Isle of Sheppey in Kent; this marks a turning point in the intensity of raids.
836	A fleet of 25-35 Danish ships arrive at Carhampton and beat back King Egbert of Wessex.

838	The Battle of Hingston Down sees King Egbert of Wessex defeat a combined force of Cornishmen and "a [Viking] great ship army" (-ASC).
839	King Egbert dies having made Wessex the leading Anglo-Saxon kingdom.
844	According to the Annals of St Bertin, England suffer a great defeat by the Vikings.
850-851	A Viking fleet create a fortified camp to overwinter on the Isle of Thanet in Kent; this is the first Vik.
851	King Aethelwulf of Wessex defeats the Vikings at Aclea.
851	The Battle of Sandwich sees Prince Aethelstan of Wessex (son of Aethelwulf) defeat the Vikings in a navy battle and capture 9 ships.
851 Spring	A Viking fleet of 350 ships arrive in Kent and then sack Canterbury and London where they "put Beorhtwulf to fight" and won.
852	King Beohrtwulf of Mercia dies and is succeeded by Burgred.
853-854	The Vikings return and overwinter on the Isle of Thanet in Kent.
855	King Aethelwulf of Wessex takes a year-long journey to Rome to visit Pope Leo IV.
865	The Great Heathen Army arrive at Thanet, led by Ivar, Halfdan, and Ubba and numbering around 3000; despite the people of Kent offering Danegeld in exchange for peace, the Vikings begin to rampage across the country; this marks the shift in the Vikings' motives from strandhogg attacks to invasion and settlement.
865	The Great Heathen Army march into East Anglia, where "the army was supplied with horses" (-ASC) by King Edmund along with other supplies in order to divert them.
867 March 21st	The Battle of York sees the Northumbrian kings Aella and Osberht unite to recapture York but they are both killed and "an excessive slaughter of the Northumbrians" (-ASC) takes place; The Great Heathen Army conquer Northumbria; they rename York 'Jorvik' and establish the puppet king Ecgberht.

867-868	The Great Heathen Army march into Mercia and overwinter in Nottingham where they are besieged by a combined force from Mercia and Wessex; nevertheless, Nottingham remains in Viking control.
868-869	The Great Heathen Army return to York and overwinter.
869 November	The Great Heathen Army conquer East Anglia by killing King Edmund; Edmund became a martyr after the Danes beat, shot, and beheaded him for refusing to denounce Christ.
870	The Vikings attempt to invade Wessex but fail to overpower King Aethelred and his brother Alfred; the Vikings withdraw to London and then York.
871	A Viking reinforcement, led by Bagsecg and numbering around 1000, arrive and join the effort against Wessex.
871 January 8th	The Battle of Ashdown sees the West Saxons under their future king, Alfred, defeat the reinforced Great Heathen Army; Bagsecg is killed.
871 April 23rd	King Aethelred I of Wessex dies and is succeeded by his brother Alfred because his two sons were too young.
871 April	The Great Heathen Army march to Wessex but relocate to London after Alfred the Great pays them to leave.
871-872	The Great Heathen Army overwinter in London and Viking coins are minted under the name Halfdan.
873-874	The Great Heathen Army successfully invades Mercia, capturing the royal centre at Repton where they then overwinter.
874	The Great Heathen Army conquers Mercia by driving King Burgred into exile and establishing the puppet king Ceolwulf II "a foolish king's thegn" (-ASC).
874	The Great Heathen Army splits in two: Halfdan consolidates his hold on York while The Great Summer Army, led by Guthrum, Oscetel and Anund, march to Cambridge to continue invading.
876	Halfdan distributed land in Northumbria amongst his men, who "ploughed the land and provided for themselves," (-ASC) and destroyed several monasteries.

876	Guthrum and The Great Summer Army capture the West Saxon fortress at Wareham where they are then besieged by King Alfred.
876	The Treaty at Wareham sees both sides pay tribute to one another, exchange 10 hostages as a sign of trust, and Guthrum swears oaths to Alfred on a golden arm-ring sacred to Thor; in the night, the Vikings kill the Anglo-Saxon hostages and flee to Exeter.
877	The Great Summer Army retreat to Mercia and occupy the eastern half of the kingdom, while their puppet king Ceolwulf II ruled the western half.
878	A Viking fleet of 23 ships, led by Ubba and numbering around 1200, arrive in Devon and besiege the West Saxon fortress at Countisbury.
878	The Battle of Cynwit sees Ubba and 800 men of his army be killed by the West Saxons; the 'Raven Banner', said to have been made by the daughters of Ragnar Lothbrok, is captured.
878 January 6th	Guthrum invades Wessex by attacking King Alfred at Chippenham and driving him to flee to the Somerset marshes; here in Athelney, Alfred organises a West Saxon counter-attack.
878 May	The Battle of Edington sees The Great Heathen Army, led by Guthrum, be defeated by King Alfred of Wessex.
878 May	The Treaty of Wedmore sees the defeated Guthrum agree to withdraw his men from Wessex; he and 30 Viking nobles are baptised as Athelstan, the adoptive son of King Alfred.
878	After Edington, The Great Heathen Army begin to settle across The Five Boroughs (Lincoln (85ac), Nottingham (31ac), Derby (65ac), Stamford (13+8.5ac), and Leicester); like burhs, they were stationed on rivers and recycled Roman defences.
879	After Edington, Guthrum becomes King of East Anglia and his army "settled there and shared out the land." (-ASC).
879	After Edington, King Alfred of Wessex creates fyrds and sets up 33 burhs in southern England so that his entire kingdom was within a 32km radius of a burh; the Burghal Hidage documents how 27,071 soldiers (approximately 1/4 of all free men in Wessex) were employed to garrison the 65km of fortifications.

c.879	King Ceolwulf II of Mercia dies and is succeeded by the Ealdorman Aethelred.
883	King Alfred of Wessex besieges London.
884	Guthrum attacks Kent but is defeated; this led to the Treaty of Alfred and Guthrum.
c.884	The Treaty of Alfred and Guthrum set out the boundaries of Alfred's kingdom: "up on the Thames, and then up on the Lea, and along the Lea unto its source, then straight to Bedford, then up on the Ouse unto Watling Street" ending at the Mersey; notably, north-east of this border is not strictly declared unified Danelaw.
c.885	The burh at Lydford is built to be surrounded by valleys with one exposed side defended by a bank 200m long and 12m wide; it may have functioned as a market centre for tin.
885	The First Battle of the River Stour sees King Alfred of Wessex attack the Danelaw coast and wipe out 16 Viking ships; when departing, Alfred's fleet is then attacked and defeated.
885	A large Viking fleet arrives and besieges Rochester.
886	Guthrum supports the Viking fleet in their attempt to besiege Rochester; leading to Alfred retaliating by seizing London and installing a permanent garrison there.
886	Alfred begins to sign charters as "rex Angul-Saxonum" rather than "rex Saxonum", and refers to his people as "Angelcynn" in order to 'shape an English imagination' (-Sarah Foot).
886	The Ealdorman Aethelred of Mercia marries Alfred's daughter, Aethelflaed.
886	King Alfred of Wessex conclusively reoccupies London and begins to repair the pre-existing Roman fortifications; London is placed under the control of the Ealdorman Aethelred of Mercia.
890	Guthrum dies.
c.891	Pope Formosus issues a papal letter to the bishops of England, complaining that "the abominable rites of the pagans have sprouted again in your parts."
892	Prince Edward marries Ecqwyn and has a son called Athelstan.

892	The Second Great Heathen Army, containing 330 longships 80 of which were led by Hastein the "kindler of evil" (-DSQ) who had spent the previous 30 years plundering around Boulogne, camps at Appledore and builds a fort at Milton Regis in north Kent; the army's women and children are dropped off at Benfleet.
892	The Battle of Farnham sees Sigurd Bloodhair's army be intercepted and defeated by a West Saxon army under Edward, son of King Alfred.
893	King Alfred of Wessex raises the fyrds of Somerset Wiltshire and Hampshire, calling upon the freemen and ensuring that "half his men were at home, half on service" (-ASC) to create a more coordinated system of defence.
893	The Battle of Buttington sees The Second Great Heathen Army, reinforced by the East Anglian and Northumbrian Danes, be defeated by an Anglo-Welsh alliance; the Vikings flee and attempt to raid the burh at Chichester but, manned by 1500 men, the garrison "put many [Vikings] to flight and killed hundreds of them and captured some of their ships" (-ASC).
894	The Battle of Benfleet sees ealdorman Aethelred of Mercia storm Hastein's camp and capture his ships and booty, along with his wife and two sons.
894	Hastein sails up the Thames and builds a fort but is forced to retreat after Alfred builds a stockade in 895.
896	After being unable to decisively overpower King Alfred of Wessex's defences, Hastein's fleets return to Francia.
896	King Alfred commissions a small fleet of (c.12) warships, each with 60 oars and said to be twice the size of Viking warships; to train his navy, Alfred recruited experienced Frisian sailors.
899 October 26th	King Alfred of Wessex dies and is remembered as Alfred the Great; based on Asser's description, his death was due to Crohn's disease; he is succeeded by his son Edward.
899	King Edward the Elder moves an army to Badbury Rings forcing his rebellious cousin, Aethelwold, to flee.
901	King Edward the Elder marries Aelflaed.

902	Aethelwold "induced the army in East Anglia to break the peace," (-ASC) persuading the East Anglian Danes to invade Mercia.
902 December 13th	The Battle of the Holme sees Aethelwold and King Eohric of East Anglia be killed; had Aethelwold won, he would have been king.
909	King Edward the Elder and Aetheflaed lead a joint Wessex-Mercia army to attack the Northumbrian Danes and "many thousands of men were killed." (-ASC)
910	The Battle of Tettenhall sees the Northumbrian Danes retaliate but be defeated; the Viking kings Haldfan, Ivar and Eowils are killed.
911	Ealdorman Aethelred dies and Aethelflaed becomes the Lady of the Mercians; throughout the 910s Aethelflaed begins to expand into the Danelaw.
912	Edward the Elder builds an earthwork in Witham that prohibits Viking movement westward and freed the Anglo-Saxon citizens from Viking control.
912-918	The South of the Humber Danes are ousted from power and their colonies are all annexed to Wessex under Edward the Elder.
912	Aethelflaed establishes burhs at Scergeat and Bridgenorth.
913	Aethelflaed fortified the burh at Stafford with a wooden stockade; it may have functioned as the community's collection point.
914	Aethelflaed establishes a burh at Eddisbury, making use of the ancient 20-acre hill-spur camp.
915	Aethelflaed establishes a burh at Runcorn to block the river route from the Irish sea into North Mercia.
917	The Battle of Tempsford sees Edward the Elder defeat the Vikings and kill Jarl Toglos, Jarl Manna, and King Guthrum II of East Anglia.
917	"The [Scandinavian] army which belonged to Cambridge chose [Edward], especially as its lord and protector." (-ASC)

917	Burhs at Huntingdon and Colchester are "repaired and restored." (-ASC)
917	Aethelflaed retakes the Borough of Derby
918	Aethelflaed retakes the Borough of Leicester.
918	The Battles of Corbridge on the banks of the Tyne River sees an army of Englishmen, fighting under the Norse King Ragnald, defeat the Scots; Ragnald then makes himself King of York.
918	The Danes of Northumbria submit to Aethelflaed.
918	Aethelflaed dies having built 10 burhs and successfully combated the Danelaw as Lady of Mercia; King Edward claims direct control of Mercia.
918	King Edward retakes the Borough of Nottingham and builds a second burh on its south bank in 920, connecting it to the other burh via a bridge which was "repaired and manned." (-ASC)
918	King Edward retakes the Boroughs of Stamford and Lincoln; marking the Anglo-Saxon recapture of all Five Boroughs of the Danelaw.
919	King Edward takes Aethelflaed's daughter, Aelfwyn, to Wessex to inhibit her claim to Mercia.
919	King Edward formally annexes Mercia.
924	King Edward dies fighting Mercian and Welsh rebels; he is succeeded by the son from his first marriage, Aethelstan.
927	King Aethelstan captures York by defeating Sihtric Caech ('squinty'), extending his rule into Northumbria; it is at this point that Aethelstan appropriately calls himself the King of all England.
937	The Battle of Brunanburh sees King Aethelstan crush the alliance of King Olaf Guthfrithsson of Dublin, Constantine and Owen of Strathclyde; 5 Norse kings and 7 Jarls of Olaf are killed and the Anglo-Saxon chronicles burst into poetry to express the significance of the Vikings' defeat.
939	King Aethelstan dies having united all of England under a single ruler; he is succeeded by his half-brother, Edmund; his absence allows Olaf Guthfrithsson to reclaim the Danelaw in 940.

941	Olaf Guthfrithsson dies on campaign and is succeeded by his cousin Olaf Sihtricsson.
942	King Edmund recaptures the Five Boroughs from Olaf Sihtricsson.
944	King Edmund temporarily recaptures York from Olaf Sihtricsson.
946	King Edmund dies and is succeeded by his brother Eadred.
948	Erik Bloodaxe temporarily recaptures York.
954	The last remaining Viking King in England, Eric Bloodaxe, is defeated and York is incorporated back into Anglo-Saxon territory under King Eadred; Eric flees York flees across the Pennine hills but is killed; hereafter England's unity is not significantly threatened.
962	King Edgar the Peaceful issues a law code addressing the "English, Danes, or Britons" of his kingdom.
980-991	During the reign of King Aethelred the Unready, small-scale raids from Scandinavia, Ireland and Normandy resume.
991	Pope John XV arranges a peace treaty between King Aethelred the Unready and Richard of Normandy.
991 August 11th	The Battle of Maldon sees a Viking fleet of 93 ships under Olaf Tryggvasson defeat King Aethelred the Unready; Aethelred pays the first tributary Danegeld of 3300kg of silver to stop "the great terror they were causing along the coast" but the army pillages Northumbria in 993, and the Viking victory causes raiding to resume.
994-995	Olaf Tryggvasson's army overwinters in Southampton.
995	Olaf Tryggvasson accepts Aethelred's £16,000 tribute and returns to Norway to take the throne.
997	King Aethelred the Unready publishes two distinct law codes, one for greater Wessex at Woodstock, and one for the Danelaw at Wantage.
1002	King Aethelred the Unready pays a £24,000 tribute to the Vikings.

1002 November 13th	St Brice's Day Massacre sees Aethelred the Unready decree that all Danes in England were "to be destroyed by a most just extermination"; 38 men in Oxford and Sweyn Forkbeard's sister were killed.
1003	In response to St Brice's Day Massacre, Svein Forkbeard returns with an army, takes Exeter, and pillages from Wessex to Wilton.
1005	Vikings return home while England suffers a great famine.
1006-1007	A "great fleet" (-ASC) under Tostig takes Sandwich and overwinters at the Isle of Wight before receiving a £36,000 tribute to leave.
1009 August	An "immense raiding army" (-ASC) under Thorkell pillages Sandwich but receives a £3,000 tribute to leave Kent.
1011-1012	Thorkell's "immense raiding army" (-ASC) besieges Canterbury; when Archbishop Aelfheah of Canterbury was martyred in the process, Thorkell defects and gifts 45 ships to the Anglo-Saxons.
1012	King Aethelred pays a £48,000 tribute to Thorkell's "immense raiding army" and they "dispersed as widely as it had been collected." (-ASC)
1013	King Aethelred uses money from the Danegeld tax to create and fund the Thingmen, a standing army of 3000 Viking warriors and a fleet of 40 ships.
1013	Svein Forkbeard returns to England and besieges London, leading to King Aethelred fleeing to Normandy.
1013 December 25th	Svein Forkbeard is declared King of England but dies 5 weeks later; his eldest son succeeded him as King Harald II of Denmark, and his younger son, Cnut, was seen by the Danelaw as King of England.
1016	King Cnut of Denmark defeats Edmund Ironside, becoming the undisputed King of England; in a letter to his subjects, Cnut calls himself "King of all England and Denmark and the Norwegians and of some of the Swedes."
1016	King Cnut flattens the burh at Lydford to establish permanent settlements; its walls of height of 2-3m with width of 9-12m were destroyed and the ditches filled in.
1042	Edward the Confessor becomes king.

